

|                                                                                   |                          |                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|  | <b>Division/Section</b>  | Family Support                                  |
|                                                                                   | <b>Chapter No./Name</b>  | 04 – Economic Stability (ES)                    |
|                                                                                   | <b>Part No./Name</b>     | P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program |
|                                                                                   | <b>Section No./Name</b>  | P-400-STEP Participation                        |
|                                                                                   | <b>Document No./Name</b> | P-430-STEP Reporting Hours and Documentation    |
|                                                                                   | <b>Effective Date</b>    | January 1, 2021                                 |

## I. STATEMENT OF POLICY

The Department, in compliance with federal, state, and/or internal regulations, is mandated to verify and document STEP participation hours.

Participation hours in both contracted and non-contracted activities must be reported. Satisfactory or unsatisfactory attendance must be documented **\* in Person Notes. \*\***

If it is determined that the client is not participating in accordance with their FSA, **\*\*\*** and if the client is not granted a good cause reason from participation, a STEP sanction is **\* requested \*\*** (Refer to P-500-STEP).

### P-431-STEP - PO CONTRACTED ACTIVITIES

Contracts with service providers must include a provision that the contractor is responsible for collecting and reporting participation hours for participants covered under their contract. The contractor must provide a case management function which will ensure that attendance and progress are monitored. The client may be required to sign in and out as appropriate so that the contractor may collect and report accurate data. A tracking mechanism such as a login/logout time function may be used by the contractor. The contractor must report participation hours to the **\* DCFS** office no less frequently than monthly.

ES contract managers must ensure that contractors adhere to the reporting requirements in their contracts or non-financial agreements. Financial contracts must include a provision to withhold partial payments if participation hours are not reported timely or correctly. Non-financial agreements should include a provision to modify or terminate the agreement if participation hours are not reported timely or correctly.

### P-431-1-STEP - PO Information Security

The Department, in compliance with internal regulations, is mandated to secure a participant's personal information, which is prohibited from being saved or stored on computers and data communication systems owned by and/or administered by DCFS.

### P-432-STEP - PO NON-CONTRACTED ACTIVITIES

Work-eligible recipients who are employed or participating in an activity must provide verified participation hours to the STEP **Coach. \*\*** Hours must be reported by the due date for each assigned work activity.

Failure of a work-eligible recipient to report participation hours in an activity by the due date for each assigned work activity will result in a STEP sanction.

Hours of participation must be verified by someone who oversees the participant's work activity.

|                                                                                                                                                                                       |                          |                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Department of<br/>Children &amp;<br/>Family Services</b><br><i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i> | <b>Division/Section</b>  | Family Support                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Chapter No./Name</b>  | 04 – Economic Stability (ES)                    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Part No./Name</b>     | P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Section No./Name</b>  | P-400-STEP Participation                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Document No./Name</b> | P-430-STEP Reporting Hours and Documentation    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Effective Date</b>    | January 1, 2021                                 |

## **P-433-STEP - PO DOCUMENTATION FOR EMPLOYMENT ACTIVITIES**

Documentation of STEP participation hours in Unsubsidized Employment, Subsidized Public Sector Employment, Subsidized Private Sector Employment, or On-the-Job Training (OJT) must be provided to the **STEP Coach** at least every six months.

## **P-434-STEP PO - DOCUMENTATION FOR NON-EMPLOYMENT ACTIVITIES**

Documentation of STEP participation hours in Job Search and Job Readiness, Work Experience Program (WEP), Community Service Programs, Vocational Education, Job Skills Training, Education Directly Related to Employment, Secondary/GED, or Provision of Child Care for Community Service must be provided to the **STEP Coach** no less frequently than monthly.

## **II. PROCEDURES**

Depending on the type of activity, it is the responsibility of either the contractor or the client to report participation hours to the **STEP Coach** in various timeframes as described below.

As part of the case management process, the **STEP Coach must** thoroughly explain the reporting requirements to the client, making sure that the client understands the reporting requirements and the penalties for failure to meet these requirements. The **STEP Coach must** maintain regular contact with the client to ensure that participation is satisfactorily continuing and that no problems are being experienced. Document satisfactory or unsatisfactory attendance in **Person Notes**.

If the **STEP Coach** believes the client is not participating in accordance with their FSA, the **STEP Coach \*\*** should follow-up with:

- site visits to verify attendance or participation,
- more frequent contacts with the client,
- communication with the contractor or employer, and/or

**\*\*\***

- comparison of participation with simplified reports.

Participation hours in all activities should be considered and/or counted in accordance with the criteria described for each specific work activity in [P-420-STEP](#).

Excused absences are countable up to 16 hours per month but not to exceed 80 hours in a preceding 12-month period. These hours are countable only if the individual was scheduled to participate on those days and only the regularly scheduled amount of daily participation hours in that activity can be counted.

Only the following 10 holidays when recognized by the work site sponsor or training or educational institution can be counted as participation hours for unpaid work activities: New Year's Day (1 day), Martin Luther King Jr. Day (1 day), Mardi Gras Day (1 day), Good Friday (1 day), Memorial Day (1

|                                                                                                                                                                                       |                          |                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Department of<br/>Children &amp;<br/>Family Services</b><br><i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i> | <b>Division/Section</b>  | Family Support                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Chapter No./Name</b>  | 04 – Economic Stability (ES)                    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Part No./Name</b>     | P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Section No./Name</b>  | P-400-STEP Participation                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Document No./Name</b> | P-430-STEP Reporting Hours and Documentation    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Effective Date</b>    | January 1, 2021                                 |

day), Independence Day (1 day), Labor Day (1 day), Veteran's Day (1 day), Thanksgiving (1 day), and Christmas (1 day).

These hours are counted only if the individual was scheduled to participate on those days and only the regularly scheduled amount of daily participation hours in that activity can be counted. For example, if a participant attends a Vocational Educational Training class for four hours per day and the Vocational Institution is closed for Labor Day, four hours of participation will be counted for that participant for that day. Holidays not listed may be counted as an excused absence up to 16 hours per month but not to exceed 80 hours in the preceding 12 month period.

Participation hours can only be rounded on a monthly basis prior to entry **\* in LITE**. Actual daily or weekly hours and minutes must be added until a monthly figure is obtained, and then that amount may be rounded to the nearest participation hour.

#### **P-431-STEP - PR CONTRACTED ACTIVITIES**

The client may be required to sign in and out as appropriate so that the contractor may collect and report accurate data. A tracking mechanism such as a login/logout time function may be used by the contractor.

Non-financial agreements should include a provision to modify or terminate the agreement if participation hours are not reported timely or correctly. The STEP **Coach \*\*** must inform STEP providers of clients referred for services on form [STEP 16R](#) as noted in their contract. **\*\*\***

A client should not be sanctioned when the contractor does not report participation hours timely or correctly, unless it is later determined that the hours were not reported because the client did not participate or because the client failed to report the hours to the contractor. When a contractor does not timely report hours, the STEP **\* Coach must** contact the contractor to determine why the hours were not reported. If the contractor simply failed to report the hours without justifiable reason, the ES contract manager should be informed and appropriate action should be taken.

#### **P-431-1-STEP - PR Information Security**

To ensure compliance with information security by the Louisiana Department of Children and Family Services (DCFS), participant's personal information such as, but not limited to, resumes, cover letters, and job search applications is prohibited from being saved or stored on computers and data communication systems owned by and/or administered by **the contractor. \*\*** Specific questions regarding this guideline should be directed to the appropriate **\*\*\* \* STEP Supervisor. \*\***

ES contract managers must ensure contracts or non-financial agreements include this provision.

|                                                                                                                                                                                       |                          |                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Department of<br/>Children &amp;<br/>Family Services</b><br><i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i> | <b>Division/Section</b>  | Family Support                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Chapter No./Name</b>  | 04 – Economic Stability (ES)                    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Part No./Name</b>     | P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Section No./Name</b>  | P-400-STEP Participation                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Document No./Name</b> | P-430-STEP Reporting Hours and Documentation    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Effective Date</b>    | January 1, 2021                                 |

## P-432-STEP - PR WORK ACTIVITIES

The reporting of verified participation hours requirement should be clearly indicated on the client's Family Success Agreement \*\*\* and discussed with the client throughout the certification. A tracking mechanism such as a login/logout time function may be used for activities; such as, GED programs, technical and/or post-secondary institutions or an on-line distance learning curriculum.

For Job Search activities, the form [STEP 11](#) should be used by the participant to document employer contacts, job search by telephone, in person, or via internet for learning of suitable job openings, applying and interviewing for jobs, and the results of such contacts. All contacts must be accompanied by the signature of an employer, work-site sponsor, or other responsible party. Daily supervision and documentation are required in order to count Job Search activities. Daily, in-person contact can be by telephone or electronic contact where those methods are suitable.

For all other work activities, the form [STEP 34A](#) or [STEP 34B](#) should be used to document participation hours. Accompanying supervisor's or provider's signature is required. Other acceptable methods of documenting participation hours in activities include:

- check stubs,
- written employer/provider records, or
- properly documented verbal verification of actual participation hours \* in Person Notes.

## P-433-STEP - PR DOCUMENTATION FOR EMPLOYMENT ACTIVITIES

Work-eligible recipients who are participating in Unsubsidized Employment, Subsidized Public Sector Employment, Subsidized Private Sector Employment, or On-the-Job Training (OJT) must provide documentation of participation hours to the STEP Coach at least every six months. This documentation may be in the form of:

- check stubs,
- written employer/provider records; such as time cards, sign-in and sign-out sheets, and rosters
- documented wage forms which include the actual hours of participation, the employer's name/signature and telephone number, or
- documented verbal verification from the employer if, and only if, check stubs or written verification cannot be obtained.

Note: The STEP Coach must document the phone call including who verified the hours of participation and the number of hours in Person Notes. \*\*

Based on valid documentation, the participation hours may be projected for up to six months or until the end of the FITAP certification period, whichever is shorter, if representative of continuing circumstances. The projection must be based on prior, documented actual hours of work. At the end of this six-month period, or at any time the worker becomes aware of a change in the client's work situation, new valid documentation must be obtained and another six-month projection may be made.

|                                                                                                                                                                                       |                          |                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Department of<br/>Children &amp;<br/>Family Services</b><br><i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i> | <b>Division/Section</b>  | Family Support                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Chapter No./Name</b>  | 04 – Economic Stability (ES)                    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Part No./Name</b>     | P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Section No./Name</b>  | P-400-STEP Participation                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Document No./Name</b> | P-430-STEP Reporting Hours and Documentation    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Effective Date</b>    | January 1, 2021                                 |

\* The STEP Coach must report documentation of employment to the local ES worker within 2 days of their knowledge of the change.

NOTE: If a Redet or Simplified Reporting will occur in fewer than six months, projection should be made to the next Redet or Simplified Reporting date.

Example: Client reports and verifies employment of 32 hours per week. The hours are entered in LITE as 32 hours per week for the next six months. Two months later, which is four months prior to the end of the six-month projection, the client reports and verifies an increase in employment hours. The client's new weekly hours must be projected again up to a maximum of another six-month period. If this client's redet is in three months, the new projection should only extend to the redet month, at which time another projection will be made.

### P-434 STEP - PR DOCUMENTATION FOR NON-EMPLOYMENT ACTIVITIES

Work-eligible recipients who are participating in Job Search and Job Readiness, Work Experience Program (WEP), Community Service Programs, Vocational Education, Job Skills Training, Education Directly Related to Employment, Secondary/GED, or Provision of Child Care for Community Service Participant must provide documentation of participation hours to the STEP Coach no less frequently than monthly. This documentation requirement must be clearly indicated on the participant's Family Success Agreement and must \*\* be discussed with the participant throughout the certification period. When possible, the form [STEP 34A](#) or [STEP 34B](#), with appropriate signatures should be used to report participation hours in these activities.

### III. FORMS AND INSTRUCTIONS

STEP 6 [Form](#) / [Instructions](#) Family Success Agreement

\*\*\*

STEP 11 [Form](#) / [Instructions](#) Employer Contact Record

STEP 16R [Form](#) / [Instructions](#) STEP Referral Log

STEP 34A [Form](#) / [Instructions](#) Attendance Record

STEP 34B [Form](#) / [Instructions](#) Vocational Education Weekly Attendance Report

### IV. REFERENCES

Code of Federal Regulations, Title 45: [Parts 261, 262, 263, and 265](#)

[TANF Final Rule 2008](#)

|                                                                                                                                                                                       |                          |                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Department of<br/>Children &amp;<br/>Family Services</b><br><i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i> | <b>Division/Section</b>  | Family Support                                  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Chapter No./Name</b>  | 04 – Economic Stability (ES)                    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Part No./Name</b>     | P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Section No./Name</b>  | P-400-STEP Participation                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Document No./Name</b> | P-430-STEP Reporting Hours and Documentation    |
|                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Effective Date</b>    | January 1, 2021                                 |

[Act 58, 2003 Reg. Session.](#)